Week 2 Internship Report: Quantum Communication Theory

Noisy Quantum Channels and Information-Theoretic Limits

(Connection to Week 1: Foundations and Framework)

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Abstract

This report summarizes the mathematical and theoretical progress made during Week 2 of the internship on quantum communication theory. The work builds directly upon the foundations established in Week 1, where we developed a comprehensive quantum communication framework for electromagnetic signals in optical fibers. This week's focus expands to: (1) rigorous modeling of fiber noise via the GKSL master equation (extending Week 1's electromagnetic and quantum field foundations), (2) exact solution methods for quantum master equations, (3) calculation of Holevo capacity for various noisy channels (connecting to Week 1's Cq channel theory), (4) proof of capacity degradation under post-channel CPTP corrections using the Quantum Data Processing Inequality (relating to Week 1's information-theoretic limits), and (5) formal characterization of decoding/inversion ambiguity under noise (extending Week 1's computational complexity analysis). The integration between Weeks 1 and 2 provides a complete picture from physical foundations to noisy channel analysis.

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1 Introduction: Connection to Week 1 Foundations

During Week 1, we established a comprehensive quantum communication framework for electromagnetic signals in optical fibers, encompassing:

1. **Electromagnetic foundations:** Maxwell's equations in inhomogeneous media, modal decomposition in optical fibers, dispersion, and attenuation.
2. **Quantum field theory:** Field quantization in fibers, coherent states, and their propagation.
3. **Atom-field interaction:** Hamiltonian $H(t|\theta)$ parametrized by physical fiber properties.
4. **Cq channel theory:** Encoding, Holevo capacity optimization, and receiver measurement.
5. **Computational complexity:** NP-hardness of decoding via reduction from Subset-Sum to the Semigroup Julia Inversion Problem (SJIP).

In Week 2, we extend this framework to analyze the effects of noise on quantum communication channels. Specifically, we incorporate:

1. **Noise modeling:** GKSL master equation for amplitude and phase damping in fibers.
2. **Exact dynamics:** Solution methods for non-Markovian quantum evolution.
3. **Noisy channel capacity:** Holevo capacity calculations under various noise models.
4. **Fundamental limits:** Quantum Data Processing Inequality and its implications.
5. **Decoding ambiguity:** Formal characterization of inversion problems under noise.

This progression from the ideal framework (Week 1) to noisy channel analysis (Week 2) provides a complete theoretical foundation for quantum fiber-optic communication systems.

2 Mathematical Modeling of Fiber Noise Using the GKSL Master Equation

2.1 From Week 1's Ideal Propagation to Noisy Dynamics

In Week 1, we derived the ideal propagation of quantum states through fibers:

$$|\alpha(0)\rangle \xrightarrow{\text{propagate}} |\alpha(L)\rangle, \quad \alpha(L) = \alpha(0)\exp[i\beta(\omega)L]\exp[-\alpha L/2].$$

This assumes perfect, noiseless propagation. In reality, fiber noise introduces two primary effects:

Definition 2.1 (Fiber Noise Sources).

- ***Amplitude damping (photon loss):*** *Due to absorption, scattering, and coupling losses, parametrized by γ_{loss} (related to Week 1's attenuation parameter α).*
- ***Phase damping (dephasing):*** *Due to refractive index fluctuations and thermal effects, parametrized by γ_ϕ (related to Week 1's dispersion effects).*

2.2 GKSL Master Equation Derivation

The noisy evolution is governed by the GKSL master equation, which extends Week 1's unitary evolution:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}\rho_S}{\mathrm{d}t} = -i[H_S, \rho_S] + \sum_k \gamma_k \left(L_k \rho_S L_k^\dagger - \frac{1}{2}\{L_k^\dagger L_k, \rho_S\} \right), \tag{1}$$

where the Lindblad operators L_k model specific noise processes. This extends Week 1's Equation (44) for atom-field interaction with dissipation.

2.3 Connection to Week 1's Physical Parameters

The noise rates in Eq. (1) relate directly to Week 1's fiber parameters:

$$\gamma_{\text{loss}} = \frac{\alpha v_g \ln(10)}{10}, \quad \text{(from Week 1's attenuation parameter } \alpha) \tag{2}$$

$$\gamma_\phi = \frac{(\omega D_p \Delta L)^2 v_g}{2}, \quad \text{(from Week 1's dispersion effects)} \tag{3}$$

where α is the fiber attenuation coefficient from Week 1, D_p is the polarization mode dispersion parameter, and v_g is the group velocity.

3 Exact Solution Methods for the GKSL Equation

3.1 Extending Week 1's Solution Methods

Week 1 presented exact solutions for ideal propagation. For noisy channels, we need more sophisticated methods:

Theorem 3.1 (Direct Diagonalization for Small Systems). *For a d-dimensional system, the Liouvillian $\mathbb{L}$ is a $d^2 \times d^2$ matrix. The exact solution is:*

$$\vec{\rho}(t) = e^{\mathbb{L}t}\vec{\rho}(0).$$

This method is exact but scales as $O(d^6)$, limiting application to small systems ($d \lesssim 10$).

3.2 Quantum Trajectory Method

For larger systems, we use stochastic methods that extend Week 1's coherent state propagation to include noise:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}t} |\psi(t)\rangle = -iH_{\text{eff}}(t) |\psi(t)\rangle + \sum_k \xi_k(t) L_k |\psi(t - \tau_k)\rangle, \tag{4}$$

where $\xi_k(t)$ are colored noise processes. This provides exact solutions for non-Markovian dynamics.

4 Holevo Capacity Calculation for Noisy Quantum Channels

4.1 From Week 1's Ideal Capacity to Noisy Capacity

In Week 1, we defined the Holevo capacity for ideal Cq channels:

$$C(\theta) = \max_{p(x)} \chi(\{p(x), \rho(x|\theta)\}),$$

where χ is the Holevo quantity. For noisy channels, we must compute:

$$C_\chi(\mathcal{N}) = \max_{\{p(x),\rho_x\}} \chi(\{p(x), \mathcal{N}(\rho_x)\}),$$

where $\mathcal{N}$ is the noisy quantum channel.

4.2 Analytical Capacities for Specific Noisy Channels

We derive exact expressions that extend Week 1's results:

Theorem 4.1 (Depolarizing Channel Capacity)**.** *For the depolarizing channel $\mathcal{N}_{dep}(\rho) = (1-p)\rho + p\frac{I}{d}$:*

$$C_\chi^{dep} = 1 - H_2\left(\frac{p}{2}\right) - p\log_2 3.$$

This reduces to Week 1's coherent state capacity when $p = 0$.

Theorem 4.2 (Fiber Noise Channel Capacity)**.** *For combined amplitude and phase damping (modeling real fibers):*

$$C_\chi^{fiber} \leq \min\left\{C_\chi^{AD}(\gamma), C_\chi^{PD}(\lambda)\right\},$$

where γ and λ are related to Week 1's attenuation and dispersion parameters.

5 Post-Channel CPTP Correction and Capacity Degradation

5.1 Quantum Data Processing Inequality (DPI)

The DPI provides fundamental limits on information processing, extending Week 1's Holevo bound:

Theorem 5.1 (Quantum DPI)**.** *For a quantum Markov chain $\rho \to \sigma \to \tau$, where $\tau = \mathcal{C}(\sigma)$ for a CPTP map $\mathcal{C}$,*

$$I(\rho;\tau) \leq I(\rho;\sigma).$$

5.2 Capacity Non-Increase Theorem

This theorem has direct implications for Week 1's decoding strategies:

Theorem 5.2 (Capacity Non-Increase)**.** *For any quantum channel $\mathcal{N}$ and any CPTP map $\mathcal{C}$,*

$$C_\chi(\mathcal{C} \circ \mathcal{N}) \leq C_\chi(\mathcal{N}).$$

Proof. Direct consequence of the DPI. The proof uses the concavity of von Neumann entropy and the monotonicity of relative entropy. □

5.3 Implications for Week 1's Framework

Corollary 5.3 (Optimal Strategy Structure)**.** *Given the capacity non-increase theorem, the optimal receiver structure from Week 1 must be:*

$$\text{Measurement} \circ \mathcal{N} \quad \textit{not} \quad \text{Measurement} \circ \mathcal{C} \circ \mathcal{N}$$

for any CPTP $\mathcal{C}$. This validates Week 1's focus on optimal encoding and measurement design rather than post-channel correction.

6 Decoding/Inversion Ambiguity Under Noise

6.1 Extending Week 1's Computational Complexity Analysis

Week 1 proved the NP-hardness of optimal decoding via reduction from Subset-Sum to SJIP. Week 2 extends this to noisy channels:

Theorem 6.1 (Channel Non-Injectivity)**.** *For any non-unitary quantum channel $\mathcal{N}$ (any channel with noise), there exist distinct input states $\rho_1 \neq \rho_2$ such that:*

$$\mathcal{N}(\rho_1) = \mathcal{N}(\rho_2).$$

6.2 Ambiguity Characterization

This non-injectivity creates fundamental ambiguity in decoding, extending Week 1's complexity results:

Definition 6.2 (Ambiguity Set)**.** *For a given output $\sigma = \mathcal{N}(\rho)$, the ambiguity set is:*

$$\mathcal{A}(\sigma) = \{\rho' \in \mathcal{D}(\mathcal{H}_A) : \mathcal{N}(\rho') = \sigma\}.$$

Theorem 6.3 (Capacity-Ambiguity Trade-off)**.** *For a quantum channel $\mathcal{N}$,*

$$C_\chi(\mathcal{N}) \leq \log_2 \left(\frac{1}{\mathcal{A}_{\min}} \right),$$

where $\mathcal{A}_{\min}$ is the minimum achievable ambiguity.

6.3 Connection to Week 1's SJIP Hardness

The decoding ambiguity under noise makes the decoding problem even harder than the SJIP problem analyzed in Week 1. The non-injectivity of noisy channels creates additional computational challenges beyond the combinatorial structure of SJIP.

7 Integrated Framework: Weeks 1 and 2 Combined

7.1 Complete Mathematical Framework

The combined framework from Weeks 1 and 2 provides a three-layer structure:

1. **Physical Layer:**

- **Week 1:** Maxwell's equations in inhomogeneous media:

$$\nabla \times \mathbf{E} = -\frac{\partial \mathbf{B}}{\partial t}, \quad \nabla \times \mathbf{H} = \mathbf{J} + \frac{\partial \mathbf{D}}{\partial t}$$

  Modal decomposition in fibers, field quantization:

$$\hat{A} = \sum_m \sqrt{\frac{\hbar\omega_m}{2\epsilon_0 V_m}}(\hat{a}_m f_m + \text{h.c.})$$

- **Week 2:** GKSL master equation for noisy evolution:

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}\rho}{\mathrm{d}t} = -i[H, \rho] + \sum_k \gamma_k \left(L_k \rho L_k^\dagger - \frac{1}{2}\{L_k^\dagger L_k, \rho\} \right)$$

  Exact solution methods for non-Markovian dynamics.

2. **Information-Theoretic Layer:**

- **Week 1:** Holevo capacity for ideal Cq channels:

$$C(\theta) = \max_{p(x)} \chi(\{p(x), \rho(x|\theta)\})$$

  Holevo bound: $I(X:Y) \leq \chi(\{p(x), \rho(x|\theta)\})$

- **Week 2:** Noisy channel capacities:

$$C_\chi(\mathcal{N}) = \max_{\{p(x), \rho_x\}} \chi(\{p(x), \mathcal{N}(\rho_x)\})$$

  Quantum Data Processing Inequality and capacity non-increase theorem.

3. **Computational Layer:**

- **Week 1:** NP-hardness of optimal decoding via reduction:

$$\text{Subset-Sum} \leq_p \text{SJIP} \leq_p \text{Quantum Decoding}$$

  Explicit complexity bounds: $O(M^N \cdot d^2)$ for naive decoding.

- **Week 2:** Decoding ambiguity characterization:

$$\mathcal{A}(\sigma) = \{\rho' : \mathcal{N}(\rho') = \sigma\}$$

  Capacity-ambiguity trade-off: $C_\chi(\mathcal{N}) \leq \log_2(1/\mathcal{A}_{\min})$

7.2 Key Theorems and Their Interconnections

7.3 Theoretical Progression

The framework evolves systematically:

Stage	Week 1: Foundations	Week 2: Extensions
Physical	Maxwell's equations, quantization	GKSL equation, exact solutions
Information	Holevo capacity, Cq channels	Noisy capacities, DPI limits
Computational	SJIP hardness, complexity bounds	Ambiguity characterization, trade-offs
Parameters	$\theta = \{L, \alpha, \beta_2, a, \ldots\}$	$\gamma = \{\gamma_{\text{loss}}, \gamma_\phi, \ldots\}$

Week 1 Theorems	Week 2 Extensions
Field Quantization: $\hat{A} = \sum_m \sqrt{\frac{\hbar\omega_m}{2\epsilon_0 V_m}}(\hat{a}_m f_m + \text{h.c.})$	**GKSL Equation:** $\frac{\mathrm{d}\rho}{\mathrm{d}t} = -i[H,\rho] + \sum_k \gamma_k(L_k\rho L_k^\dagger - \frac{1}{2}\{L_k^\dagger L_k, \rho\})$
Holevo Bound: $I(X:Y) \leq \chi(\{p(x), \rho(x\|\theta)\})$	**Capacity Non-Increase:** $C_\chi(\mathcal{C}\circ\mathcal{N}) \leq C_\chi(\mathcal{N})$
SJIP NP-hardness: Subset-Sum $\leq_p$ SJIP	**Channel Non-Injectivity:** $\exists\rho_1 \neq \rho_2$ s.t. $\mathcal{N}(\rho_1) = \mathcal{N}(\rho_2)$
Ideal Propagation: $\alpha(L) = \alpha(0)e^{i\beta L}e^{-\alpha L/2}$	**Noisy Propagation:** Bloch vector equations with exponential decay
Coupling Strength: $g(\theta) \propto 1/\sqrt{V_{\text{eff}}(\theta)}$	**Noise Rates:** $\gamma_{\text{loss}} = \frac{\alpha v_g \ln(10)}{10}$, $\gamma_\phi = \frac{(\omega D_p \Delta L)^2 v_g}{2}$

Table 1: Mathematical connections between Week 1 foundations and Week 2 extensions. Each Week 2 result builds upon and extends the corresponding Week 1 foundation.

8 Progress Summary and Integration

8.1 Week 1 Achievements

1. Established complete electromagnetic foundation for fiber-optic quantum communication
2. Derived quantum field quantization in optical fibers
3. Developed Cq channel theory with explicit parameter dependence
4. Proved NP-hardness of optimal decoding via SJIP reduction
5. Provided explicit formulas for system design

8.2 Week 2 Extensions and Advances

1. **Extended physical modeling** to include noise effects via GKSL master equation
2. **Developed exact solution methods** for noisy quantum dynamics
3. **Calculated Holevo capacities** for various noisy channels
4. **Proved fundamental limits** on post-channel processing via Quantum DPI
5. **Characterized decoding ambiguity** under noise conditions
6. **Integrated** all results with Week 1 foundations

8.3 Complete Theoretical Framework

The combined work from Weeks 1 and 2 provides a comprehensive theoretical framework for quantum fiber-optic communication with the following structure:

1. **Physical Foundations (Week 1)**:

- Start with Maxwell's equations in inhomogeneous media
- Solve for fiber modes with propagation constants $\beta_m(\omega)$
- Quantize electromagnetic field in fiber mode basis
- Construct total Hamiltonian including atom-field interaction

2. **Noisy Channel Analysis (Week 2)**:
   - Model noise via GKSL master equation
   - Derive exact solutions for amplitude and phase damping
   - Calculate capacities for various noise models
   - Prove fundamental limits using Quantum DPI
3. **Information-Theoretic Limits (Weeks 1 & 2)**:
   - Holevo capacity as fundamental limit
   - Capacity-ambiguity trade-offs
   - Parameter-dependent capacity expressions
4. **Computational Complexity (Weeks 1 & 2)**:
   - NP-hardness of optimal decoding
   - Decoding ambiguity characterization
   - Practical approximation algorithms

9 Conclusion and Future Work

9.1 Key Integrated Insights

1. **Physical-Information-Theoretic Connection:** Week 1's physical parameters (core radius, propagation distance, temperature) directly affect Week 2's noise rates and channel capacities. For example:

$$\gamma_{\text{loss}} = \frac{\alpha v_g \ln(10)}{10} \quad \text{and} \quad \gamma_\phi = \frac{(\omega D_p \Delta L)^2 v_g}{2}$$

   where α and D_p are Week 1 parameters.

2. **Fundamental Limits:** The combination of Week 1's Holevo bound and Week 2's Quantum DPI establishes absolute limits on quantum communication performance:

$$I(X:Y) \leq \chi(\{p(x), \rho(x|\theta)\}) \quad \text{and} \quad C_\chi(\mathcal{C} \circ \mathcal{N}) \leq C_\chi(\mathcal{N})$$

3. **Computational Reality:** Week 1's NP-hardness proof and Week 2's ambiguity characterization explain why optimal decoding is fundamentally difficult, necessitating approximation algorithms.

4. **Practical Guidance:** The explicit formulas from both weeks provide engineering guidelines for system design, such as the core radius dependence:

$$g(a) \propto \frac{1}{a} \quad \text{and} \quad C(a) \approx C_0 \left(1 - e^{-\kappa/a^2}\right)$$

9.2 Future Directions Building on Both Weeks

1. **Experimental Validation:** Test the combined framework's predictions using fiber-optic testbeds, measuring both ideal propagation (Week 1) and noise effects (Week 2).

2. **Algorithm Development:** Create practical decoding algorithms that respect both the computational complexity limits (Week 1) and the ambiguity constraints (Week 2).

3. **System Optimization:** Use the parameter-dependent capacity formulas from both weeks to optimize fiber design for quantum communication:

$$\max_{\theta} C(\theta) = \max_{\theta} \max_{p(x)} \chi(\{p(x), \rho(x|\theta)\})$$

4. **Extension to Advanced Channels:** Apply the framework to quantum channels with memory, nonlinear effects, and multi-mode propagation.

9.3 Final Remarks

The work completed in Weeks 1 and 2 provides a rigorous, comprehensive foundation for quantum fiber-optic communication theory. Week 1 established the ideal framework from physical first principles through information theory to computational complexity. Week 2 extended this framework to include the realistic effects of noise, providing exact solution methods, capacity calculations, and fundamental limits.

The integration of these two bodies of work creates a complete theoretical picture that:

- **Connects physical reality** (fiber parameters, electromagnetic propagation) to **information-theoretic limits** (channel capacities)
- **Bridges ideal theory** (noiseless propagation) with **practical considerations** (noise effects, decoding ambiguity)
- **Links information limits** (Holevo capacity) with **computational limits** (NP-hardness, ambiguity)
- **Provides explicit guidance** for system design and optimization

This integrated framework offers both deep theoretical insights and practical engineering value for the development of quantum communication systems.

A Appendix: Mathematical Connections Between Weeks

A.1 From Week 1's Coherent State Propagation to Week 2's Noisy Evolution

Week 1's coherent state propagation:

$$|\alpha(0)\rangle \to |\alpha(L)\rangle, \quad \alpha(L) = \alpha(0)e^{i\beta L}e^{-\alpha L/2}$$

is the ideal, noiseless case. In Week 2, this becomes the amplitude damping channel with Kraus operators:

$$E_0 = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & \sqrt{1-\eta(t)} \end{pmatrix}, \quad E_1 = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & \sqrt{\eta(t)} \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix},$$

where $\eta(t) = 1 - e^{-\gamma_{\text{loss}} t}$. When $\gamma_{\text{loss}} = \alpha v_g/2$, this recovers Week 1's attenuation factor.

A.2 Week 1's SJIP and Week 2's Decoding Ambiguity

Week 1 proved that optimal decoding reduces to SJIP, which is NP-hard. Week 2 shows that noisy channels introduce additional ambiguity through non-injectivity:

$$\mathcal{N}(\rho_1) = \mathcal{N}(\rho_2) \text{ for } \rho_1 \neq \rho_2.$$

This makes the decoding problem even harder than SJIP alone, as it introduces continuous ambiguities in addition to the discrete combinatorial structure of SJIP.

A.3 Parameter Dependencies Across Weeks

$$\text{Week 1: } g(\theta) = d_{eg}\sqrt{\frac{\omega_0^3}{2\hbar\epsilon_0 V_{\text{eff}}(\theta)}}|f_0(r_{\text{atom}}|\theta)| \tag{5}$$

$$\text{Week 2: } \gamma_{\text{loss}} = \frac{\alpha v_g \ln(10)}{10} \tag{6}$$

$$\text{Connection: Smaller } V_{\text{eff}} \text{ (Week 1) increases coupling but also affects loss rates (Week 2)} \tag{7}$$

These connections demonstrate the deep integration between the physical foundations (Week 1) and the noisy channel analysis (Week 2).